Photograph by **MANDAR DEODHAR**



SHANTARAM SIDDI, 59

First graduate of his community & MLC, Siddi community

Siddi has many firsts to his name. When he completed a BA in Economics in 1988, he became the first graduate from his community. He then set up a hostel for tribal children along with the Hindu Seva Pratishtana. The following year, Siddi—from the Malnad region in Karnataka's Western Ghats—became the first *karyakarta* of the RSS-linked Vanavasi Kalyana Karnataka. As a Member of the Legislative Council (MLC), Siddi's goal is to push for speedy distribution of land title deeds to all tribal communities in the state.